

BUSTED Surat police with Selvaraj (centre) and the fake notes worth Rs 17 lakh

NIRBHAY KAPADIA

FAKE NOTES

FACT AND FICN IN BIHAR

By Amitabh Srivastava

On the night of May 22, the police in Patna got a tip-off that liquor was being sold out of a flat in Rajaram Apartments in the posh Srikrishna Puri locality. Bihar being a 'dry state', the cops quickly arranged a late-night swoop. The raid yielded a lot more than a few liquor bottles—there was Rs 1.8 lakh in counterfeit currency (in Rs 500 and Rs 200 denominations) and banknotes printed on paper sheets, ready to be cut out and circulated. A full counterfeit cottage industry, in fact: printers, paper sheets, a cutting machine and laptop.

Three of the accused managed to flee, but the cops arrested two other young men in their 20s—Ayub Khan and Ratan Yadav. Khan, who broke his leg in an abortive bid to escape, is the son of a policeman. He was staying in Patna to prepare for the civil service exams and, reportedly, was inspired by the OTT series *Farzi* to try his hand at the fake currency racket. He has since confessed to travelling to Nepal to learn the techniques for printing counterfeit currency. A series of FICN (fake Indian currency note) busts in the past few months—from Ayub Khan to third-year college student Rahul Vadodaria in Gujarat (arrested on May 1 with 134 fake notes of Rs 100 denomination) to the five men arrested in Noida with FICN of face value Rs 6.5 lakh in April—seems to indicate that several amateurs have gotten into the game.

DESPITE THE FAKE CURRENCY LINKS TO BIHAR, THERE HAVE BEEN VERY FEW SEIZURES IN THE STATE

What is common among many of the counterfeiting cases from the past 2-3 years is a Bihar connection. The accused in the Noida arrests had identified a Singhania from Chhapra district who printed the notes for them.

Bihar's connection to one of the biggest FICN rackets was exposed earlier this month when Surat Police arrested a 38-year-old man for supplying special bond paper and other material to a Chennai-based FICN producing unit. The Gujarat police zeroed in on Mukesh Singh, a resident of Vaishali district in Bihar, while following leads provided by victims of the Chennai supplier. Earlier, on April 21, a joint team of the Gujarat and Chennai police had arrested Surya Selvaraj in Surat and recovered FICN worth Rs 17 lakh from him.

Selvaraj led the cops to Mukesh, who was arrested on May 1. The two have admitted to supplying fake notes worth Rs 2.12 crore in at least 10 states. Besides printed fake notes, some 23,000 fake stamp papers, colour printers, paper cutters, lamination and heating machines, watermarks and 70 reams of security thread were recovered from the Chennai unit.

But surprisingly, despite the FICN links to Bihar, there are not many cases of fake currency seizures in the state. In fact, the state had only three FIRs of FICN seizures in 2020 and 36 out of a total 699 filed in the country in 2021, per National Crime Records Bureau data. A senior police officer says this could be deliberate. "Bihar is a major transit point for FICN coming in through Nepal, but those involved in the racket keep the circulation to a minimum in the state to keep investigative agencies off their back," he says.